

ENOUGH

THE JOY OF CONTENTMENT

TEXT: Philippians 4:8-13 (NKJV) *“Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things. ⁹ The things which you learned and received and heard and saw in me, these do, and the God of peace will be with you. ¹⁰ But I rejoiced in the Lord greatly that now at last your care for me has flourished again; though you surely did care, but you lacked opportunity. ¹¹ Not that I speak in regard to need, for I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content: ¹² I know how to be abased, and I know how to abound. Everywhere and in all things, I have learned both to be full and to be hungry, both to*

abound and to suffer need. ¹³ I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.”

INTRO: Philippians four is a very interesting passage of Scripture. In this passage Paul tells the Philippians, and reminds us:

- To control how we think... This is an activity reserved for each individual.
- To follow the example of Scripture and those who have set the example ahead of us... Bible heroes – Contemporary heroes.
- To do what we can, in spite of the fact that we face limitations... ***“You did what you could, but you lacked opportunity.”***
- To gracefully have plenty, and suffer lack with a good attitude... In everything Paul went through, he found a way to relax in the fact that he had ENOUGH – ***“I have learned to be content in all circumstances.”***
- To ***“Do all things through Christ”***... This is where the ability to be satisfied with ENOUGH is found – Contentment.

Paul uses the word “**content**” in verse 11. This word speaks of “*being satisfied with what one has, regardless of how small or large it might be.*” Are we contented people? Can we be satisfied with our lot in life? If we can answer yes to these questions, then we possess a great treasure.

We live in a world of discontented people! It is possible to be saved, and have much in this world, and still not be content.

Rather than living lives of grateful contentment, our lives are often filled with complaining and dissatisfaction:

- We complain about our home when thousands have no home...
- We gripe about work when many have no jobs...
- We are dissatisfied with our future when many do not even know how they will get through the day...

We must learn the secret of contentment! Benjamin Franklin said, “*Contentment makes poor men rich; discontentment makes rich men poor.*”

Proverbs 13:7 (NKJV) “***There is one who makes himself rich, yet has nothing; And one who makes himself poor, yet has great riches.***”

There is a secret to satisfaction, and Paul knew what it was. Look at his words: “***I have learned.***” This means he had gained the knowledge or understanding of living the satisfied life, of having ENOUGH.

Paul used the language of Greek “*mystery religions*”. They claimed to have special knowledge of deep, divine secrets, possessed only by the “*initiated*”. Paul borrowed their words to tell us that he had been “*initiated*” into “*The Secret Society of The Satisfied*”.

Paul had obviously discovered the secret of satisfaction and living the life of ENOUGH.

Paul goes on to let the cat out of the bag and share his secret with the Philippian Christians, and all of us. Here are the lessons to be learned from what he discloses:

LEARN TO REJOICE IN OUR SUBSTANCE

1 Timothy 6:6-8 (NKJV) “*Now godliness with contentment is great gain. ⁷ For we brought nothing into this world, and it is certain we can carry nothing out. ⁸ And having food and clothing, with these we shall be content.*” We should learn not to bemoan what we do not have, and to celebrate what we do have – We have ENOUGH!

Remember, God knows what we need and has committed Himself to supply the need!

Philippians 4:19 (NKJV) “*My God shall supply all your need according to His riches in glory by Christ Jesus.*”

It is our responsibility to celebrate what we have, and let God take care of what we need. He will supply the need either directly or indirectly. He sent ravens to feed Elijah, but showed up Himself when John was on Patmos.

We should rejoice in what we currently have and be prepared to celebrate what He brings our way in the future.

Instead of complaining about what we lack, how about praising Him for what we have?

The story is told of a lady who was existing on a daily diet of bread and water, but when she was asked about her life she said, “*I have all of this and Jesus too!*” Paul said, “*I know how to be abased and to abound...*” – Do we?

LEARN TO REST IN ALL SITUATIONS

Vs. 11 “*I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content.*”

What does it mean to be contented?

We should never settle for less than our best. We can be ambitious and still be right with God:

- One should not be satisfied with C's when they are capable of making A's...
- One should not be satisfied with a GED when they could have a Doctorate...
- One should not be satisfied riding the bench when they could be an All-American athlete...
- One should not be satisfied being an average Christian when they could be a world changer...

Self-sufficiency leads to discontentment. Self-surrender leads to true contentment –
ENOUGH!

The only path to contentment – ENOUGH – is to surrender ourselves to the Lordship of Christ! If we do this, we can learn to REST in each situation and station of life!

Self-surrender is the essence of God
-Dependence. When we surrender all to Him,
we are bequeathed hidden resources. Jesus told
the woman at the well, ***“Whoever drinks of the
water that I shall give him will never thirst.
But the water that I shall give him will become
in him a fountain of water springing up into
everlasting life.”***

People blow in, blow up, and blow out, because
they have no inner resources!

When we engage in self-surrender – Give
everything over to Jesus - We become like a
country that needs no imports – We become like
a cruise ship on the high seas - We have
everything we need because we have His
sufficiency! ***“He’s all I need. He’s all I need.
Jesus is all I need.”***

Self-surrender allows us to accept our situation,
and live in contentment – The place where we
can rest in ENOUGH!

LEARN TO UNDERSTAND THE SOURCE OF OUR STRENGTH

Vs. 13 *“I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.”*

Paul does not say *“I can’t”* – That is the language of pessimism. Pessimism is the language of the world. Optimism is the language of the Kingdom. Pessimism say’s:

- I can’t get a job...
- I can’t pay my bills...
- My disease is terminal...
- My marriage is going to end in divorce...
- My children are not going to amount to anything...
- The church can’t establish the kingdom in the earth...

Kingdom talk say’s:

- I’m about to get my best job yet...
- I am going to prosper; it is a matter of timing...

- This sickness is about to meet up with a healing Jesus...
- I am going to do what is necessary to heal my marriage, and have a God honoring home...
- My children are going to serve the Lord, and our family circle will be unbroken in Heaven...
- The church is the best thing afloat, and is bringing Heaven to earth...

This is not the language of presumption – This is the language of the Kingdom, because it is based in the faith of what God is going to do, in us, ***“through Christ.”***

CONCLUSION:

(Altar song: *“I surrender all”*)

Ladies and gentlemen, we should praise God for what we have – We are better off than 90% of the world! Most of us already have more than

what we thought we would ever have! We have ENOUGH!

No matter what we are going through we must learn to rest in the fact that God is in control, the whole day through! Our present circumstances may have taken us by surprise, but it hasn't taken God by surprise! He has already made a way out of no way! He has gone ahead of us and made *“the rough placed smooth, the crooked place straight, the high place low.”*

We must remember, all the strength we need is within – because Jesus lives here. Galatians 2:20 (NKJV) *“I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me.”*